



Q: It almost sounds like you have been on a *padyatra*...

A: Except that we are not going by foot. This is important because many a time people ask me that the bank is in a good shape, is the highest profit-making bank in the country, in fact, it is the highest profit-making company in the country, so what is the inflection point we are looking for? This outreach programme, in my view, [can] appropriately [be called] as the next leap. This outreach programme is aimed at getting feedback from the ground about what else we need to do as a bank, both in terms of serving our customers better and creating value for our stakeholders, whether they are shareholders, employees, or government regulators.

Q: What is the strategy behind strengthening the physical presence as well as the digital part of your business?

A: We have currently about 500 million customers. And hugely diversified customers as a reflection of Indian diversity. We have high networth individuals in our customer base and also zero-balance account

holders... This diversified customer base needs to be served both physically and digitally. And our physical presence is unparalleled, with around 22,500 branches... But we have also done an extensive market study and found that there are certain gaps... the newly developed townships where everyone wants to have an SBI branch. So, we are looking at a potential business opportunity in these areas.

Q: Does the Indian customer behave uniquely in the sense that he wants a physical presence, as well as have access to online payments and digital technology?

A: It is not restricted to financial services alone. Digital native companies like Amazon, Flipkart... would also like to have a physical presence. But what we want to do at the branch will probably change as we go forward... It may not be purely transaction-oriented. Today, at SBI, 97% of the transactions happen outside the branches... But even the 3-4% of the transaction volume translates to good footfalls at the branch. Two, we also want to use the branch network for quality value-added services to be delivered. They can be a